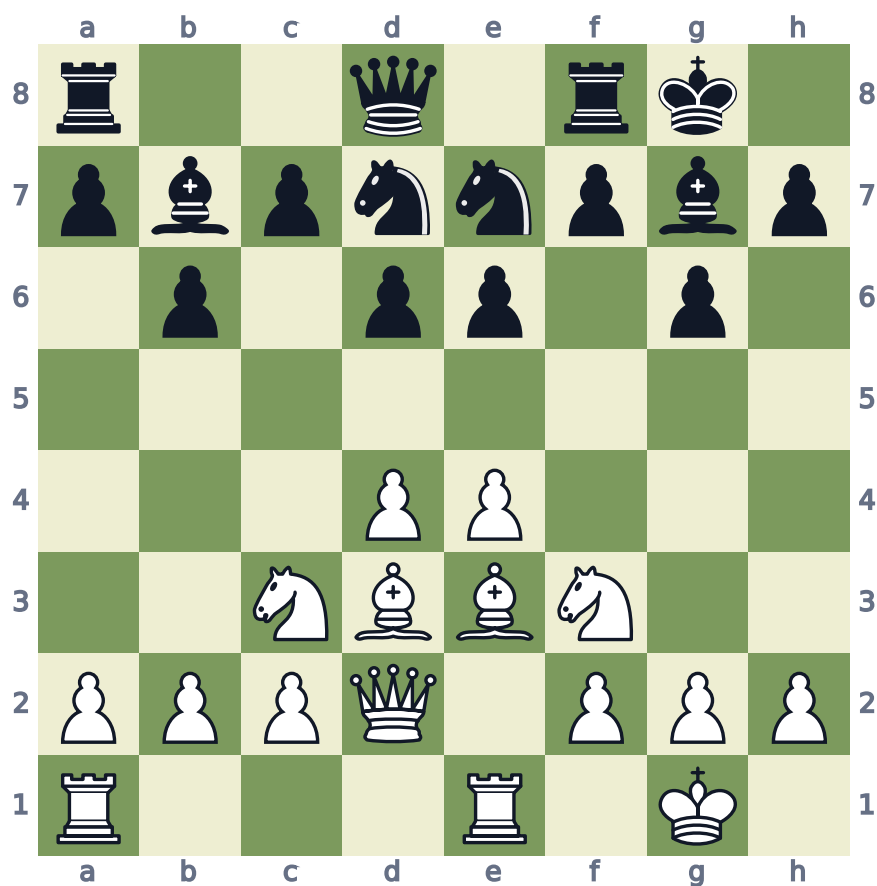


Hippo vs 1.e4: Classical Centers

Broad centers, Austrian setups, h-pawn attacks, early e5, and controlled counterplay



Meet the major 1.e4 center builds with a coherent Black Hippo while learning exactly when White's space requires an immediate reaction.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Meet the major 1.e4 center builds with a coherent Black Hippo while learning exactly when White's space requires an immediate reaction.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

Against e4 and d4, White's center is impressive but offers fixed targets.

PRINCIPLE 2

Nc3 and f4 make e5 powerful but also expose e4 and dark squares.

PRINCIPLE 3

An early h4-h5 attack changes move-order priorities around the king.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

White's e5 advance must be met before the shell becomes cramped beyond repair.

PRINCIPLE 5

Long castling often makes c5 or b5 more attractive than a kingside race.

PRINCIPLE 6

Black's objective is active counterplay, not merely surviving behind two ranks of pieces.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

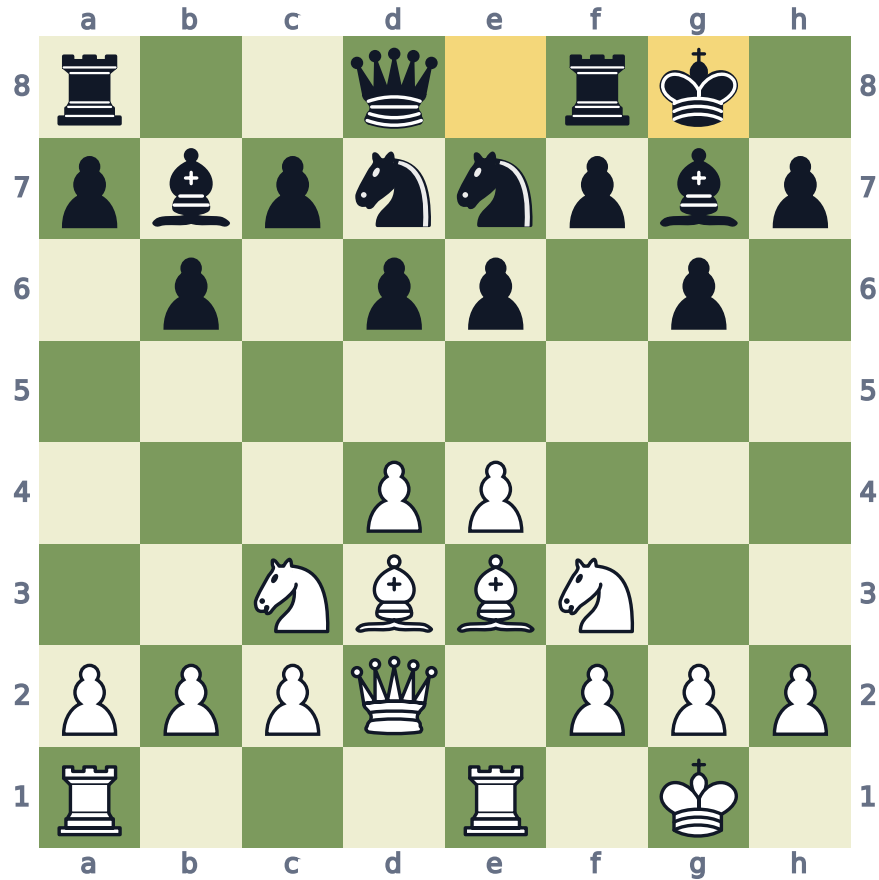
- | | | |
|-----------|---|---|
| 01 | Classical center with Nf3 and Bd3 | The classical center gives time only if every move prepares contact. |
| 02 | Austrian center and f5 counterstrike | Against f4, f5 is thematic only after king safety and piece support are checked. |
| 03 | 150 Attack style development | Qd2 and long castling move the target; answer on the queenside or in the center. |
| 04 | h4-h5 before castling | The best reply to a wing attack is often central contact, but h6 can buy the needed move. |
| 05 | White advances e5 early | An early e5 is a concrete demand; solve it before returning to setup moves. |
| 06 | White closes with d5 | A closed center is permission to maneuver only after you name the second break. |
| 07 | Four-pawn expansion | The more flank pawns White pushes, the more urgent and valuable central play becomes. |
| 08 | Long castle with h5 | Keep the king flexible until the open file and opponent's king location are known. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Classical center with Nf3 and Bd3



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 b6 8. Be3 Bb7 9. Qd2 O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

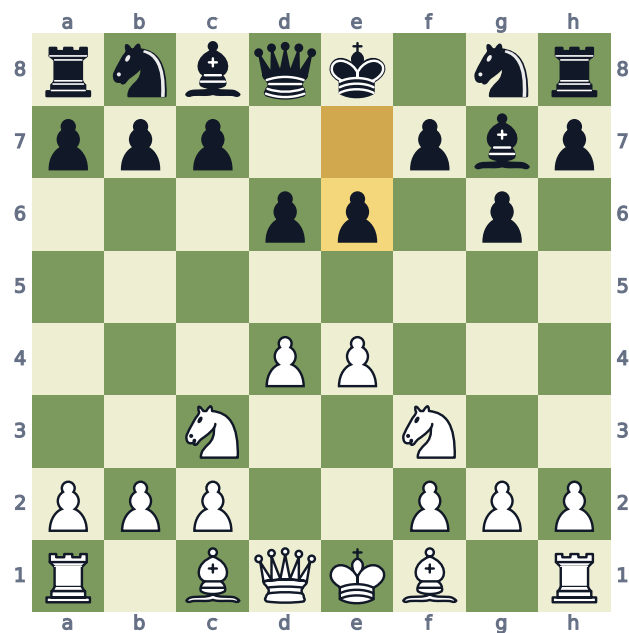
Finish development while preparing the break that attacks White's less-supported center pawn.

MAIN DANGER

White may play Bh6, e5, or h4 before Black is fully ready.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The classical center gives time only if every move prepares contact.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.99 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Rad1 Kh8 2. Bg5 f6 3. Be3 Ng8 4. h4 a6 5. a4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Classical center with Nf3 and Bd3



YOUR TASK

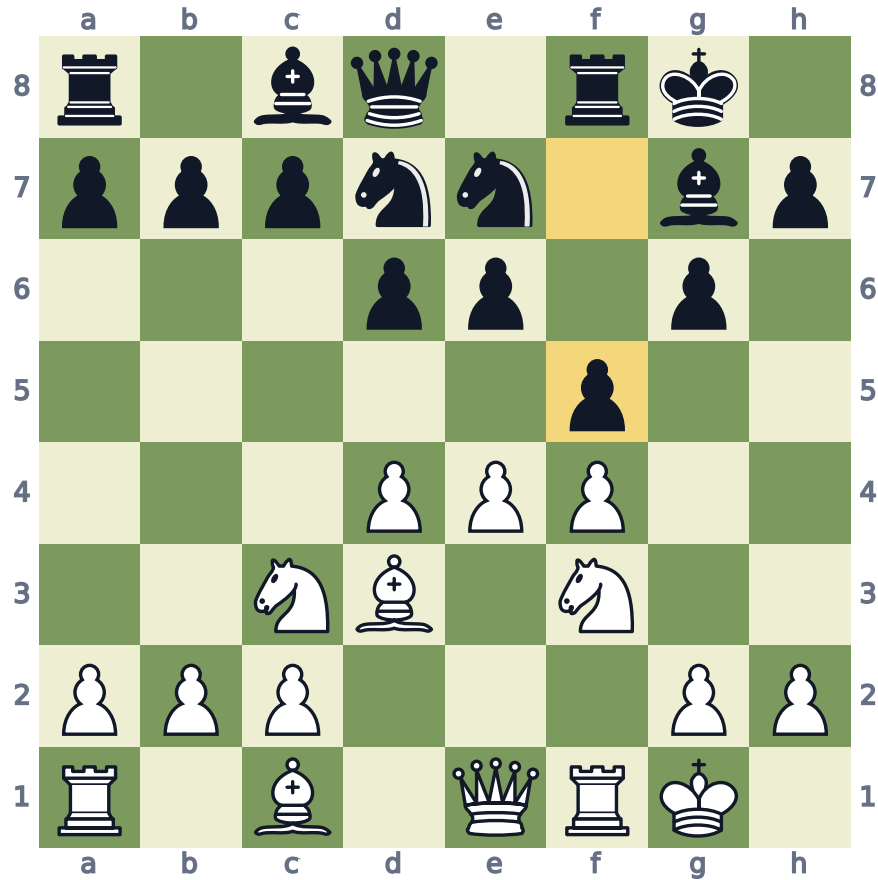
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Austrian center and f5 counterstrike



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O O-O 8. Qe1 f5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge e4 before White's e5-f5 expansion takes over the kingside.

MAIN DANGER

exf5 can open lines against Black's king and e6.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against f4, f5 is thematic only after king safety and piece support are checked.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

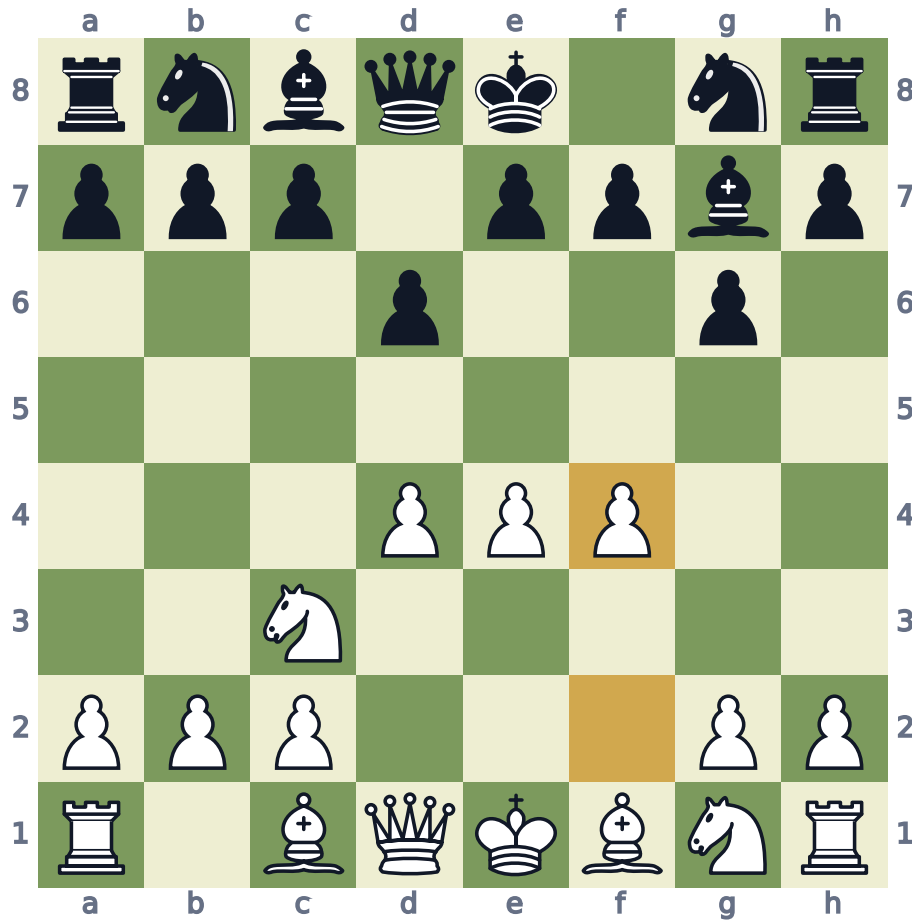
Position estimate: +1.28 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h3 Nb6 2. e5 Bd7 3. a4 Bc6 4. a5 Nbd5 5. Ng5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Austrian center and f5 counterstrike



YOUR TASK

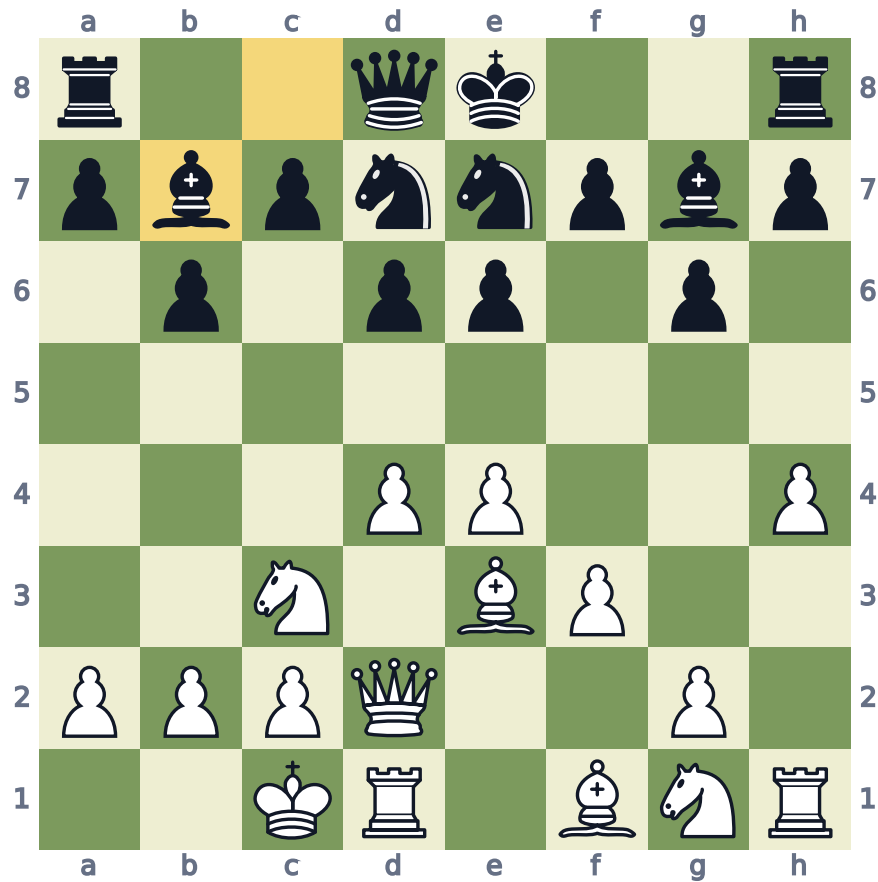
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

150 Attack style development



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. f3 Nd7 7. O-O-O b6 8. h4 Bb7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

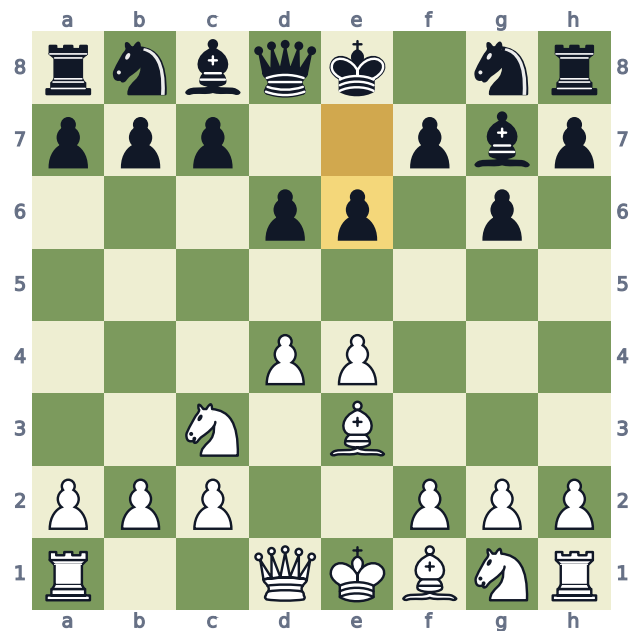
Delay castling, develop the queenside bishop, and create counterplay against the long-castled king.

MAIN DANGER

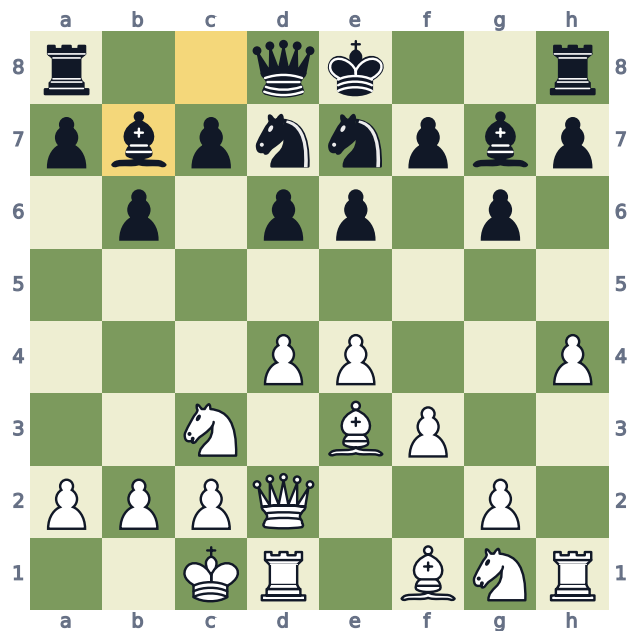
h5 can open the g-file while Black is still compact.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Qd2 and long castling move the target; answer on the queenside or in the center.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.66 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h5 h6 2. hxg6 Nxg6 3. Bxh6 Rxh6 4. Rxh6 Bxh6 5. Qxh6 a6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

150 Attack style development



YOUR TASK

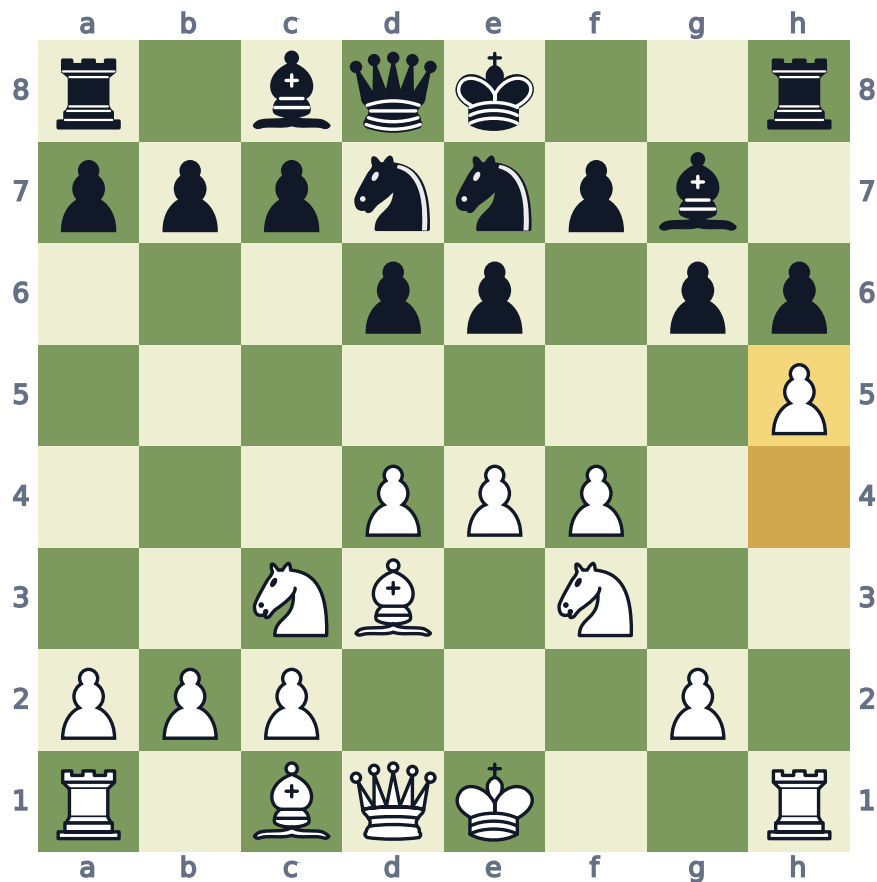
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

h4-h5 before castling



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. h4 h6 5. f4 e6 6. Nf3 Ne7 7. Bd3 Nd7 8. h5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use h6 to slow opening of the h-file and prepare a central counterblow.

MAIN DANGER

g4-g5 or hxg6 may pry open the king regardless.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The best reply to a wing attack is often central contact, but h6 can buy the needed move.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.63 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. e5 hxg6 2. Nxg6 dxe5 3. dxe5 f5 4. Nf4 Bc4 5. c6 Bb3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

h4-h5 before castling



YOUR TASK

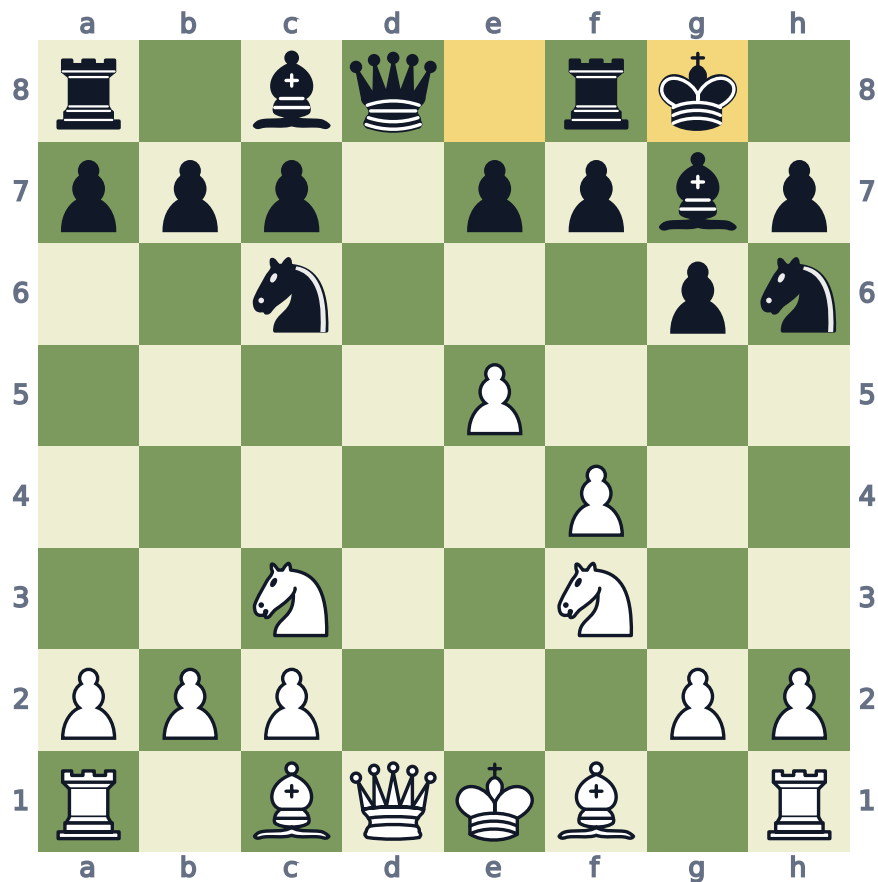
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

White advances e5 early



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e5 dxe5 5. dxe5 Nc6 6. f4 Nh6 7. Nf3 O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Eliminate the advanced pawn or pressure it before completing the Hippo shell.

MAIN DANGER

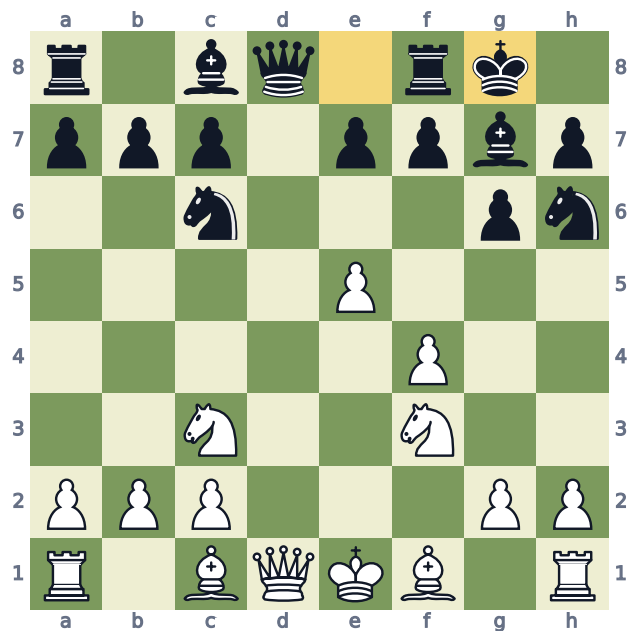
The e5 pawn can cramp both knights if Black treats it as harmless.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

An early e5 is a concrete demand; solve it before returning to setup moves.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.11 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. Be3 Bg4 2. Bf2 Qxd1+ 3. Rxd1 Bxf3 4. gxf3 Rfd8 5. Bd3 e6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

White advances e5 early



YOUR TASK

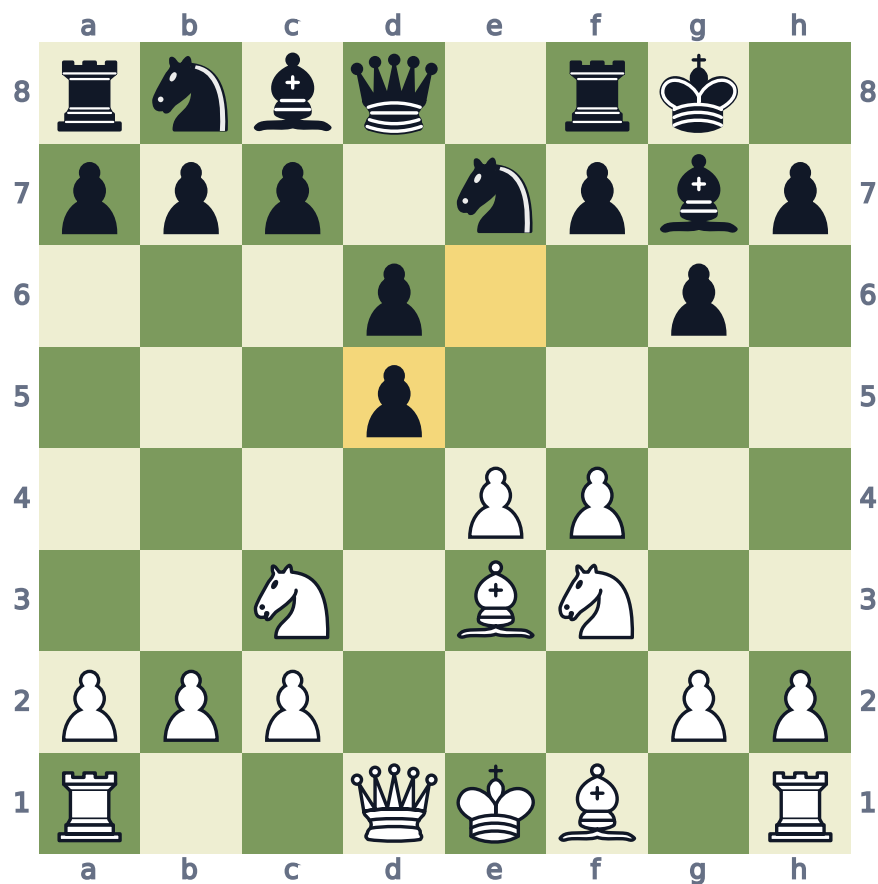
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

White closes with d5



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. d5 e6 5. f4 Ne7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be3 exd5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge the closed chain before White consolidates a space advantage.

MAIN DANGER

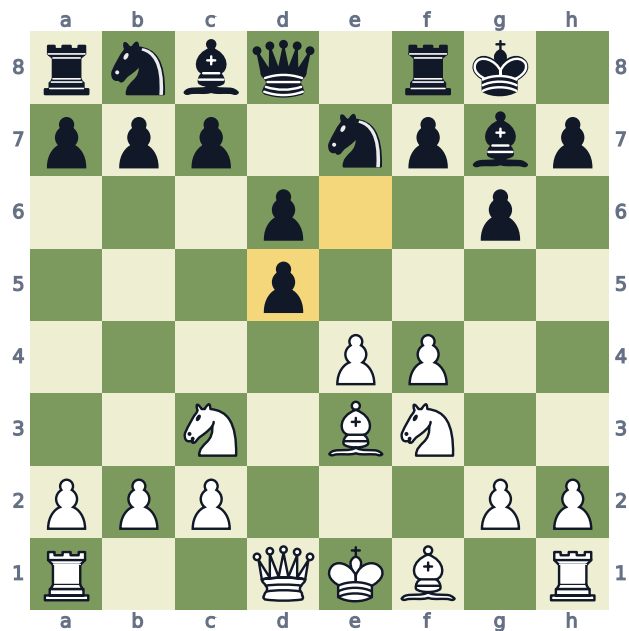
After exd5, White may gain e-file pressure and a protected passer.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A closed center is permission to maneuver only after you name the second break.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: -1.42 for White (Black is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. exd5 Bxc3+ 2. bxc3 Re8 3. Be2 Nxd5 4. Qxd5 Rxe3 5. Qd2 Re7

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

White closes with d5



YOUR TASK

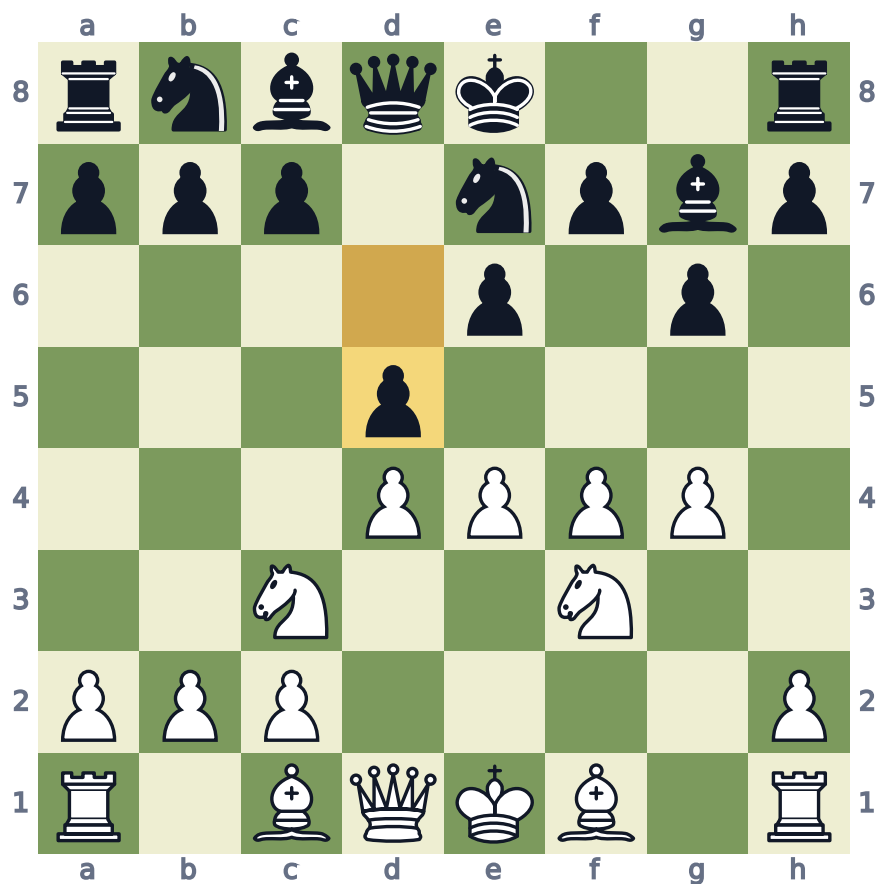
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Four-pawn expansion



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. g4 d5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Strike the center while White spends tempi expanding on the wing.

MAIN DANGER

If the center stays closed, g5 and f5 may trap Black's pieces.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The more flank pawns White pushes, the more urgent and valuable central play becomes.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.83 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. e5 h5 2. gxh5 Rxh5 3. h4 Bd7 4. Bd3 Nbc6 5. Bd2 Nb4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Four-pawn expansion



YOUR TASK

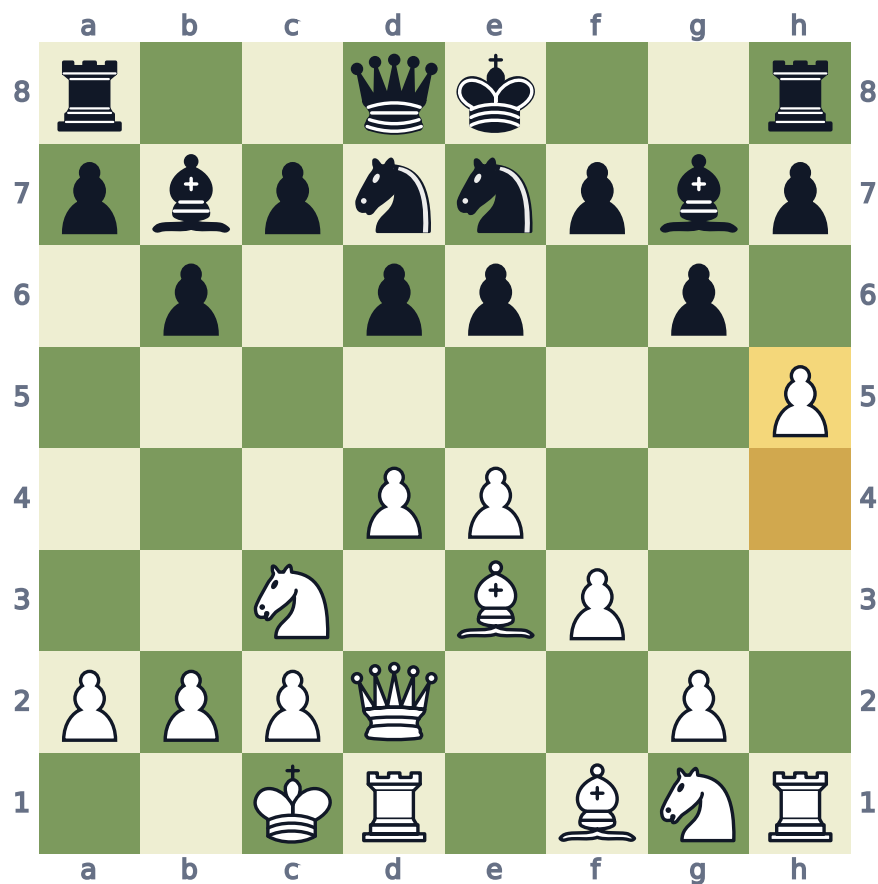
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

Long castle with h5



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f3 e6 5. Be3 Ne7 6. Qd2 Nd7 7. O-O-O b6 8. h4 Bb7 9. h5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

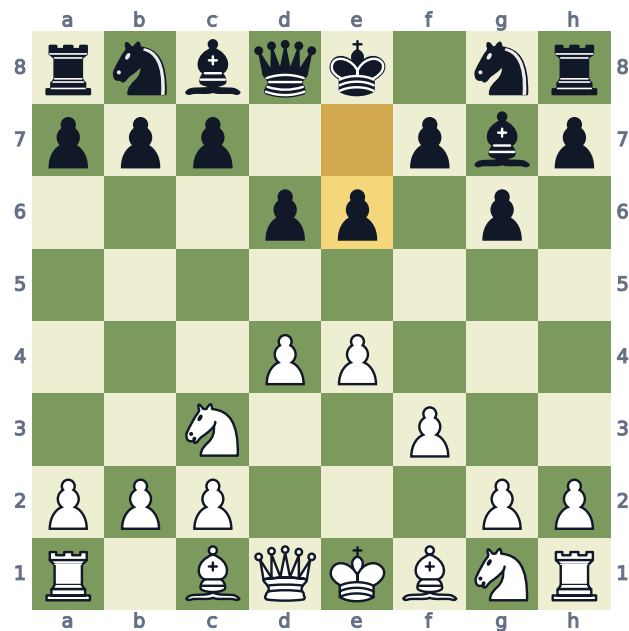
Develop Bb7 and prepare queenside play without ignoring the h-file.

MAIN DANGER

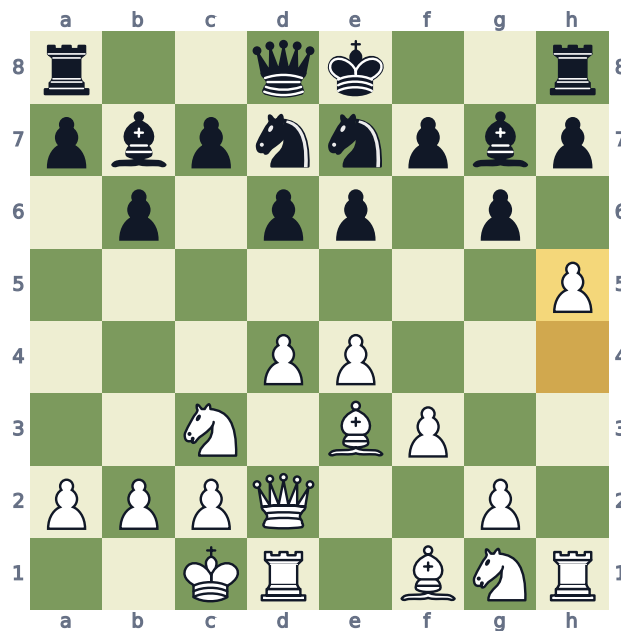
hxg6 can open a direct line to the king if Black castles short carelessly.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Keep the king flexible until the open file and opponent's king location are known.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

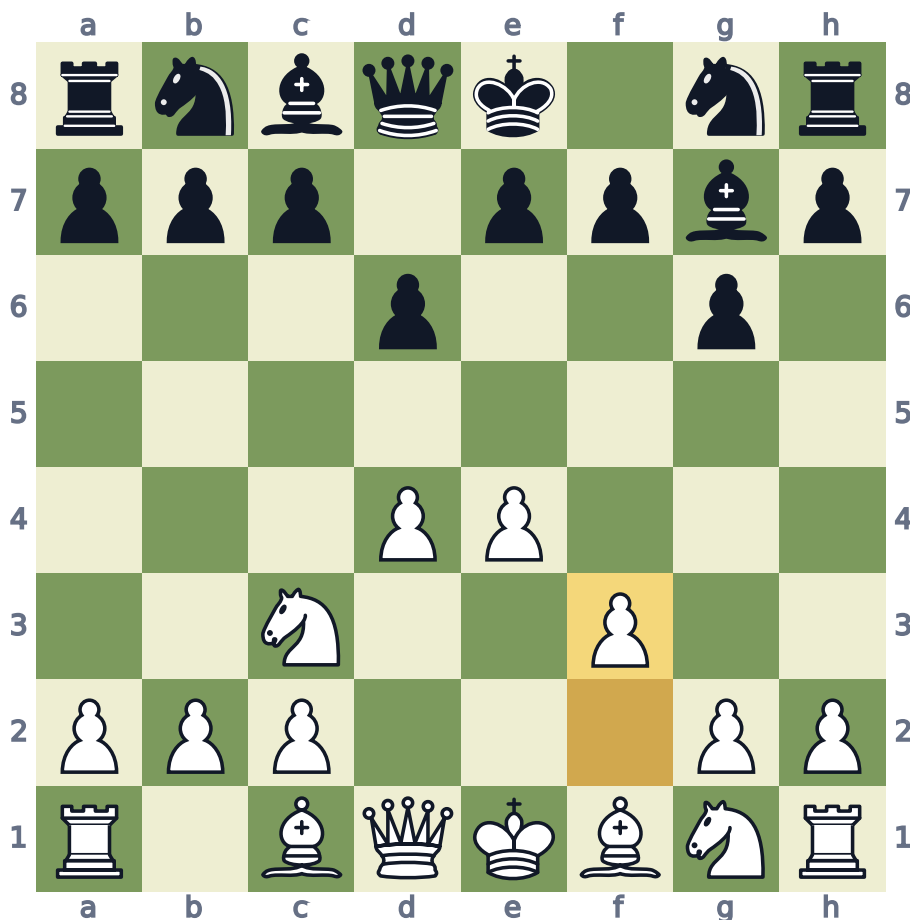
Position estimate: +1.72 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. a6 Nge2 2. b5 g4 3. Nb6 h6 4. Bf6 g5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

Long castle with h5



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. CLASSICAL CENTER WITH NF3 AND BD3

Course move: Ne7. Purpose: Finish development while preparing the break that attacks White's less-supported center pawn. Engine comparison: 1. Nc6 Bg5 2. Nge7 Qd2 3. h6 Be3 4. a6 Rd1 5. b5 O-O (+1.00 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: White may play Bh6, e5, or h4 before Black is fully ready.

02. AUSTRIAN CENTER AND F5 COUNTERSTRIKE

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge e4 before White's e5-f5 expansion takes over the kingside. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nf3 2. O-O Bd3 3. c5 dxc5 4. dxc5 h3 (+0.69 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: exf5 can open lines against Black's king and e6.

03. 150 ATTACK STYLE DEVELOPMENT

Course move: e6. Purpose: Delay castling, develop the queenside bishop, and create counterplay against the long-castled king. Engine comparison: 1. Nd7 Nf3 2. a6 a4 3. c5 dxc5 4. Nxc5 Bxc5 5. Bxc3+ bxc3 (+0.73 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: h5 can open the g-file while Black is still compact.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. H4-H5 BEFORE CASTLING

Course move: h6. Purpose: Use h6 to slow opening of the h-file and prepare a central counterblow. Engine comparison: 1. h5 Be3 2. c6 Qd2 3. b5 f3 4. a5 Bd3 5. Na6 (+0.53 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: g4-g5 or hxg6 may pry open the king regardless.

05. WHITE ADVANCES E5 EARLY

Course move: dxe5. Purpose: Eliminate the advanced pawn or pressure it before completing the Hippo shell. Engine comparison: 1. dxe5 dxe5 2. Qxd1+ Nxd1 3. Bxe5 Nf3 4. Bd6 Ne3 5. Nf6 Nc4 (-1.14 for White (Black is clearly better)). Warning: The e5 pawn can cramp both knights if Black treats it as harmless.

06. WHITE CLOSES WITH D5

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge the closed chain before White consolidates a space advantage. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Nf3 3. Nbd7 O-O (-0.03 for White (equal)). Warning: After exd5, White may gain e-file pressure and a protected passer.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. FOUR-PAWN EXPANSION

Course move: d6. Purpose: Strike the center while White spends tempi expanding on the wing. Engine comparison: 1. c6 Nf3 2. d5 e5 3. Bg4 h3 (+0.68 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: If the center stays closed, g5 and f5 may trap Black's pieces.

08. LONG CASTLE WITH H5

Course move: e6. Purpose: Develop Bb7 and prepare queenside play without ignoring the h-file. Engine comparison: 1. a6 h4 2. h5 a4 3. Nd7 Be3 4. c5 Nge2 5. cxd4 Nxd4 (+0.60 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: hxg6 can open a direct line to the king if Black castles short carelessly.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.